Deadline Reset



THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Find out what was promised, check what the team can deliver, and give the person responsible a clear choice.

Nic Payne

For you, the PM carrying this situation

The date has already been promised. Now what?

A launch date has been promised, and the team is still checking what it can deliver. Let's start with what customers were told, then work through the options together.

Start with why the date matters

Is there an event booked? Has a customer planned around it? Ask what would happen if the date changed. You need to understand the promise before proposing a different one.

Find out what kind of date it is

A target is a date we would like to hit. An estimate is when the team currently thinks it can finish. A promise is something someone has told another person they can rely on. Ask which this is and what work it includes.

Give people a choice they can understand

Perhaps customers need online booking by the event, but reports could come later. Perhaps both features matter more than the date. Work through those options with the people building the software.

What you'll leave with

The Lab helps you write down the facts, compare delivery options, and prepare an update asking for a decision. You can return after the meeting to record the answer.

Your first useful step is to get clear on the promise. From there, we can work out what's possible and what to ask next.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

You can be frustrated and still be curious.

A date that looks impossible can feel like a request to work harder. Take a moment to notice your reaction, then think about what you'd like to understand before replying.

What actually happened?

Start with what was said or done. "They asked for Friday" tells us what happened. "They don't care about the team" is an explanation you may have added. What could you ask to find out what's behind the request?

Why do you care?

Who would be better off if this worked? Perhaps a customer could stop chasing an answer, or your team could finish something it promised. Say why that matters to you, and ask what matters to the other person too.

What would better look like?

Imagine the next few weeks going well. What would people be doing differently? Describe that in ordinary words, then ask the other person what they would add or change.

Keep these notes to yourself

These questions are for your own thinking; you can answer them without typing. If you use the Lab's private notes, they stay only in the open tab. They aren't saved or exported, and disappear when you refresh or leave.

An opening you can adapt: "I want us to find a way through this. Can we look at what is happening and work out what to do next?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What is each of you trying to protect?

The person who made the promise may feel just as exposed as you do. Give them a way to explain what happened without first defending themselves.

Say what you want

I want customers to leave the event knowing what they can use. I also want the team to give us an answer it can stand behind.

Ask about their position

What have customers arranged around this date? What did we tell them? Is there something I haven't heard that makes changing it difficult?

Hear the answer

You're worried that another change will damage their trust. Have I understood? Let them correct you before introducing your options.

Bring the team in

Ask the people doing the work to explain what is ready and what still needs checking. Give them room to say they don't know yet.

You can take the promise seriously and still ask whether the current plan can deliver it.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What exactly have people been told?

“We promised November 1” is only the start. Promised what, to whom, and by whom?

Write down the promise

Name the date, the features or service promised, the people expecting it, and the person who told them. Quote the actual message if you can.

Check what really can’t change

For example, the event venue may be booked, but nobody has agreed which features must be shown. Ask the person responsible for the event or contract to confirm.

List what still needs checking

Does the booking page put appointments into the repair calendar? Can customers see only their own bookings? Has the team tested those things, or are we assuming they work?

Explain what is at risk

Say what customers could experience if the plan doesn’t work. “A customer books a repair but the service team never receives it” is more useful than “integration risk.”

Try: “I know the event is fixed. Can we check exactly what customers have been promised for that day?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What could we change?

Ask the team what each option would take. A smaller promise still needs to be useful to the customer.

Keep the date; do less

Could customers book repairs on November 1, with downloadable service reports added later? Name what would be ready and what would wait.

Keep all the work; reconsider the date

Ask the people doing the work when both features could be ready and what they still need to check. If they can't give a reliable date yet, say when they will reassess it.

Check whether more help would help

A new person needs time to learn the work. A specialist might remove a specific problem. Include the time needed to teach, review, and test; don't assume extra people instantly make delivery faster.

Keep the necessary checks

Name the security, safety, and quality checks that must still happen. Explain the consequences of skipping them. Ask the people responsible for those checks to confirm the plan.

Try: "We may be able to have booking ready for the event if reports come later. If both must be ready together, we need to review the date."

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Find the smallest promise that still helps.

A smaller list of features is useful only if it still does something worthwhile for the people waiting. Talk through that together.

1 / What must someone be able to do?

Would customers need to make a real booking at the event, or would seeing how it will work meet the need? Ask the person responsible for the customer relationship.

2 / What would each option take?

What is left to build, check, and explain? Who needs to help? Ask the team before turning an option into a promise.

3 / Who would the change affect?

If reports arrive later, who still has to prepare them by hand? Include that work and tell those people before changing their expectations.

4 / Who can change the promise?

Who can approve this particular change? Who needs to confirm the checks? The person estimating the work may not be the person allowed to change a customer commitment.

Write the recommendation as a proposal. Ask for a response before telling anyone that the promise has changed.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

How confident are we, and why?

“Medium confidence” isn’t much help on its own. Explain which work and date you mean, and what could change your view.

Name the plan you’re assessing

“Online booking by November 1” is different from “booking and reports by November 1.” Make sure everyone is talking about the same promise.

Say what you know

For example, the booking page is built and reviewed. The engineering lead has estimated the work left. Explain what those estimates are based on.

Say what you still need to find out

The engineering lead will check the calendar connection on Thursday. Until then, the date depends on that check succeeding.

Agree what happens if the check fails

Who will decide whether to show a demonstration instead? When must customers be told? Make that plan now, while there is still time to act.

The Lab doesn’t calculate the chance of hitting a date. It helps you explain your judgment and what you’ll check next.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Give uncertainty a next step.

You don’t need a confident-sounding number to be helpful. You need to explain what the team knows and how it will find out more.

What we know

The booking page is built. That is useful progress. It does not yet show that a booking reaches the repair calendar correctly.

What we will check

The engineering lead will send test bookings through on Thursday, check the results, and list any remaining work.

What could change

If the connection fails, working online booking may not be ready for the event. The smaller promise still depends on that check.

What happens then

Ask who can approve a demonstration instead and when customers must be told. Agree that response before Thursday if possible.

A review date is a promise to return with what you learned. It is not a promise that the software will be finished by then.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Give them something they can decide.

You have looked at the options. Now let's turn them into a short recommendation you can talk through. Explain your reasoning, and ask what you might have missed.

Open with the customer need

"Customers need to see online booking at the event. I want to keep that useful. Here is what the team has checked and what is still uncertain."

If the answer is "the date can't move"

"Understood. Which parts must be ready that day, and which could come later?" Bring the team into checking whether the smaller plan is possible.

If the answer is "just add people"

"Which part would another person help with? Who would get them started and check their work?" Ask the team to assess that option.

Ask for a decision and record the response

Name the person who can change the promise and when you need an answer. Record what they actually agree, decline, or ask you to check. Update customers through the person responsible for that relationship.

Try: "I recommend focusing on booking for the event and adding reports later. Can we agree that, then confirm the customer message after Thursday's check?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Help everyone hear the same plan.

The sponsor, the team, and the customer need different details. The promise and its conditions should match in every version.

Ask the person who can decide

Can we focus on booking for the event and move reports later, subject to Thursday's check? If that check fails, can we show a demonstration instead?

Tell the team what is agreed

Name the work to do, the work to pause, and the checks to keep. Until there is an answer, describe this as the plan you are asking for.

Prepare the customer message

Ask the person responsible for the customer to explain what will be available and when they will hear more. Let them review the wording before it goes out.

If nobody answers

Ask who can respond in time. Record the unanswered question and the current plan. Do what you are already authorized to do; silence does not approve the change.

In the Lab's final step, you can draft separate updates and come back to record what happened after the decision.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Online booking by November 1. Reports too?

Fictional example: a sales director has promised online repair booking and downloadable service reports for a customer event. The event is fixed. The connection between booking and the repair calendar hasn’t been tested.

What the product manager finds out

Customers need to see how booking will work at the event. No contract requires downloadable reports that day. The engineering lead needs to test the calendar connection before confirming the smaller plan.

The recommendation

Keep the event, aim for working online booking, and explain that reports will come later. Confirm what we can promise after Thursday's calendar check.

The conversation

The product manager asks the sales director to agree that reports can come later. They also agree to show a demonstration only if Thursday's calendar check fails. The sales director will explain any change to customers.

What happens next

In this example, the sales director accepts the recommendation on Wednesday. The engineering lead checks the calendar connection on Thursday. They review the result before confirming what customers can use on November 1. The Lab example starts before this agreement.

The event still matters. The team now knows what to check, and customers can be told what to expect.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Work through one promised date.

Open the Lab from your Start page. You can come back to the Guide whenever a question needs more thought.

The promise

Record what was promised, why the date matters, and what is still uncertain. Preview Deadline Facts if you need to check your understanding with someone.

Options

Write down what could be ready on the date, what a later date might allow, and whether extra help would be useful. Preview Delivery Options to compare them.

How sure are we?

Choose your current confidence, explain it, and name the next check. Say what you'll do if that check changes the plan.

The update

Write the decision you need, who can make it, and when. Preview Decision Update while it is still a proposal. Return after the meeting to record the response, then rebuild and share the updated version.

Load Examples fills only the step you're on. If it would replace existing answers, you'll be asked first.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What happened after the conversation?

Once you have talked, come back and see what changed. What helped, what still needs attention, and who needs to hear from you?

Follow up

Check that the customer message and the team's plan say the same thing. Return after the promised technical check. If the result changes what you can deliver, tell the people relying on the date.

Try saying it out loud

Read your message aloud. Does it sound like you? If a phrase feels awkward, use the words you'd say in the meeting. Someone you trust can help you spot anything that's hard to follow.

Keep the record

Copy, download, or print anything you need to keep. Shared answers save in this browser on this device; they don't follow you to another device. Private notes aren't saved. Export before clearing a draft or browser data.

Check what happened

Was the decision understood? Did someone act? Did the change help the people it was meant to help? If nobody responded, find out who can decide and agree when to ask again. Silence doesn't mean yes.

You don't have to fix the whole organization in one conversation. Leave knowing what happens next, who will do it, and when you'll check back.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Notice what the deadline taught people.

The date will pass. What people learned about speaking up, trusting each other, and making promises may last much longer.

Identity

Could someone admit uncertainty without feeling they had failed? Did you become more willing to ask for help or change your mind?

Relationship

Did Sales and Engineering understand each other better? What helped them say something difficult while staying in the conversation?

Vision

Did the customer need remain clear when the feature list changed? Can everyone explain what they are trying to make possible?

Culture

Did the next promise get checked with the team first? If overtime quietly filled the gap, what would need to change before this happens again?

Notice the effects on people as well as the delivery. Reflection can stay private; nobody needs to share personal information to use this tool.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

1 / The promise

The PM hears that online booking and reports have both been promised for November 1. Instead of opening with an argument about the date, they ask what customers are expecting.

PM

“What did we tell customers? I want to know what they’ll be expecting on the day.”

Sales director

“I said booking and reports. The event is fixed, but the thing they most want to see is booking.”

Ask yourself: Which parts of the promise have you confirmed, and which are still your interpretation?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

2 / Check the options

The engineering lead says booking may be possible if reports wait, but the calendar connection has not been tested. They keep the security review and booking checks in the plan.

PM

“If reports come later, what would you still need to check before we promise booking?”

Engineering lead

“Let me check the calendar connection on Thursday. If that doesn’t work, I’ll need to understand why before I can give you another date.”

Ask yourself: What would make the smaller promise useful and believable?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

3 / Ask for the change

The PM recommends focusing on booking, with a demonstration as a fallback if Thursday's check fails. This is still a proposal. The sales director needs to respond before the customer update.

PM

"Could reports come later? We'll know more about booking on Thursday. If it isn't ready, could we show a demo at the event and explain that?"

Sales director

"Who will tell me what the check found, and when will we update customers?"

Ask yourself: Have you named both the decision and the next check?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

4 / Record the answer

In this fictional continuation, the sales director agrees on Wednesday. The PM records that answer and its conditions. Agreement to a smaller scope is not evidence that the remaining software works.

Sales director

“Yes. Reports can come later. Tell me Thursday what the calendar check shows, and I’ll update customers by Friday.”

PM

“I’ll record that and check it with the team so we’re working from the same plan.”

Ask yourself: Does the written decision say exactly what was agreed, including the conditions?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

5 / Come back after the check

For this continuation, the calendar check finds a problem. The team uses the agreed fallback instead of pretending the smaller promise is still safe. They return to the customer and investigate before offering another date.

Engineering lead

“The test booking didn’t reach the calendar. We need to fix that before customers use it.”

Sales director

“Then we’ll show the demonstration, as agreed. I’ll explain the change and when they’ll hear from us next.”

Ask yourself: Did the plan make it easier for someone to report disappointing news in time?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

The Magic of Mr. Greenleaf — A Servant Leader's Guide to the Impossible

Nic Payne · Article

When you feel responsible for rescuing the date yourself, use Nic's story to question what the organization is asking one person to carry.

What would need to change so meeting this promise does not depend on someone quietly exhausting themselves?

Take this into your Lab >

Your Company's God is Showing

Nic Payne · Article

Look at what the deadline asks people to sacrifice and what those choices teach them about what matters here.

What are we protecting, and who is paying for that choice?

Take this into your Lab >

Leadership as bowl, water, and current

Nic Payne · Video · start at 4:19

Nic's leadership video offers a way to think about the attention you bring into a tense conversation.

What might I hear if I make room for the other person before defending my plan?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

[You Have a Culture Problem]

Nic Payne · Article

Use the four Base Elements to look beyond the event date and notice what this way of making promises creates.

What is the team learning about trust, judgment, and the future we are working toward?

[Take this into your Lab >]

[When Mattering Isn't Enough]

Nic Payne · Article

Nic asks what becomes possible after people feel valued. Consider whether this plan gives people room to learn and grow.

Where could this plan damage people, and where could it help them grow?

[Take this into your Lab >]

[Shape Up — Chapter 3: Set Boundaries]

Ryan Singer · Book chapter

Use the distinction between a time limit and the work inside it when exploring a smaller useful result.

If the event date stays, what could customers still use or learn from?

[Take this into your Lab >]

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

RAPID® Decision Making

Bain & Company · Originator's framework explanation

Clarify who recommends a change, whose approval is required, and who can change the customer promise.

Who has the authority to make this particular call?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

The thinking behind the tool.

Holistic Shaping asks what work is doing to people, as well as what people are doing at work. These short notes connect the Guide to Nic's teaching and a few practical sources. Read what helps with the situation in front of you. Links open the original resources.

Back in the Guide

CHAPTER 02

Notice what the pressure is doing between you.

A promised date can turn someone into 'the person who made the mess' and someone else into 'the person who always says no.' Nic's bowl metaphor asks us to notice how our attention shapes the conversation. Find out what the other person is carrying before deciding who they are.

Worth asking: What have you stopped asking because you think you already know their answer?

Leadership as bowl, water, and current
Nic Payne · Video · start at 4:19

CHAPTER 04

A smaller promise can protect more than the schedule.

Look at the work behind each option. Does it depend on lost sleep, skipped learning, or people saying yes when they know the plan is wrong? Ask the team what a smaller, useful delivery would let them do well. Shape Up offers a practical way to explore a fixed time limit with room to change the work.

Worth asking: Which option can people honestly stand behind and sustain?

Shape Up — Chapter 3: Set Boundaries
Ryan Singer · Book chapter

CHAPTER 05

You can be useful without pretending to know.

Nic's writing on certainty asks whether our tools help us use our judgment or let us avoid it. A confidence label does not settle the question. Explain what has been checked, what remains unknown, and when you will have a better answer.

Worth asking: What are you being tempted to make sound more certain than it is?

The Search For Unapologetic Impracticality In Leadership: Part II - The Seduction of Certainty
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 09

What will happen the next time someone promises a date?

If you keep repairing promises made without the team, the latest update may only get you through this week. In the orbital model, repeated experiences shape identity and relationships; the culture that emerges then makes those experiences feel normal. Agree how the next promise will be checked before it is made.

Worth asking: What needs to change so honesty does not depend on one person being unusually brave?

You Have a Culture Problem
Nic Payne · Article

Why Work Can't Be Your Church
Nic Payne · Article

Recover After You Missed It
Nic Payne / Rebel Leaders · Codex practice

Explore more of Nic’s Holistic Shaping work at Rebel Leaders.

The notes apply the teaching to these situations. They are not quotations unless marked. The health reflection is optional; you do not need to record or share personal information.